Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

2 Peter

2 Peter 1:1

- Simon was one of the most common Jewish names in the first century. Jesus gave him the name Peter (Matthew 16:17–18). Many people in the Greco-Roman world would use both their given name in their native language and also a Greek name. They did this because Greek was the common language used for trade and communication (see study note on Acts 7:58).
- a servant ... of Jesus Christ: In the Old Testament, important leaders of God's people are called servants of the Lord (Joshua 14:7; 24:29; 2 Kings 10:10). This title emphasizes Peter's submission to Christ and also suggests that he had an important role in God's plan.
- ours: This probably refers to Jewish Christians. The recipients of this letter were mostly non-Jewish (Gentile) Christians. In the new covenant, non-Jewish and Jewish Christians share the same precious faith and are equal as God's people (see Galatians 3:26–29).
- This is one of the few places in the New Testament where Jesus Christ is called God (see also John 1:1; 20:28; Romans 9:5; Titus 2:13; Hebrews 1:8; 1 John 5:20).

2 Peter 1:3

His divine power has: The Greek text does not use the name of God here. Peter may be referring to the divine power of "Jesus our Lord" (1:2).

2 Peter 1:3–11

God has given us many blessings through Christ (1:3–4). This provides a strong reason to encourage us to learn more about Christ (1:5–11).

2 Peter 1:4

so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature: Peter probably did not mean that our souls are merged with God but that believers share in the qualities of God's character, such as holiness and love (compare Leviticus 11:44; Matthew 5:43–48; Ephesians 4:24; 5:1).

2 Peter 1:5–7

These verses use a stair-step structure to show how each virtue leads to the next. This pattern is a common literary device called a sorites. The order is not the main point. For example, Peter is not saying that moral excellence must come before knowledge. But he does show that love is the highest and most important virtue in the list (1:7).

2 Peter 1:10

- Brothers: Here, the Greek term adelphoi refers to people who belong to the same family, both male and female.
- strive to make your calling and election sure (literally Be zealous to make certain): Peter did not mean that God's choice to save us depends on our actions. Instead, he teaches that our effort to grow in Christian virtue shows that God has already chosen us.

2 Peter 1:12–15

Peter was writing at the end of his life, and 2 Peter is similar to works that belong to a popular Jewish genre called the testament. In this genre, an older and respected leader gives final instructions to his children or to the people under his care while he is near death (see Deuteronomy 31–33; Joshua 24). This genre is especially well known from a Jewish work called The Testaments of the Twelve Patriarchs.

2 Peter 1:14

This prophecy might have come to Peter in a vision, but it is more likely that he was remembering the prophecy Jesus gave about his death (John 21:18–19).

2 Peter 1:16–18

- cleverly devised fables: The false teachers were probably claiming that the message about Christ's return was only a helpful story and not a true event.
- we were eyewitnesses of His majesty: This refers to the transfiguration of Jesus (Matthew 17:1–9; Mark 9:2–8; Luke 9:28–36). The transfiguration was a moment when the appearance of Jesus changed in a bright and glorious way. At that moment, Jesus was revealed as the glorious King, which pointed to his future return. Peter's confidence did not come from human guesses but from what he personally saw.

2 Peter 1:16–21

Peter's strong warning against the false teachers in chapter 2 is surrounded by his teaching about the certainty of the return of Jesus (see also 3:1–13). The false teachers were probably denying that Christ would truly return and judge the world. But Peter had seen Christ's glory with his own eyes (1:16–18), and the words of Scripture are completely reliable (1:19–21). These truths show that Christ's return is certain.

2 Peter 1:19

- Here, day refers to the day of the Lord. This is a time when God acts in history to save his people and judge his enemies (see Isaiah 13:4–12; Joel 2:1–32; Zephaniah 2:1–3). Christ's first coming began the day of the Lord's salvation for his people. A future day of the Lord's judgment on his enemies will occur as well.
- the morning star: The planet Venus, called the "morning star," often appears above the eastern horizon just before dawn. Peter reverses the normal order of nature. He explains that the dawning of the day of the Lord will lead to the Morning Star, Christ, shining in the hearts of believers.

2 Peter 1:20–21

comes from one's own interpretation: This probably means that the prophets did not have to interpret God's visions by themselves. God made the meaning clear to them so they could speak his message clearly and reliably.

2 Peter 2:1

- They will: Peter uses the future tense in 2:1–3, but this does not mean that false prophets had not yet appeared. Instead, he is recalling the prophecy Jesus made that false teachers would arise (Matthew 24:11, 24; Mark 13:22; compare Acts 20:29–31; 2 Timothy 3:1–6). The false teachers already present in the church were the fulfillment of that prophecy.
- denying the Master who bought them: The false teachers might have openly rejected Christ. But it is more likely that their bad behavior was a denial of Christ (compare Titus 1:16).

2 Peter 2:1–3

Along with the true prophets, there have always been false prophets, and God brings judgment on the (1:20–21).

2 Peter 2:2

One sad result of false teaching is that people will speak badly about the way of truth. When false teachers live in immoral and greedy ways, they bring shame on Christ.

2 Peter 2:4

- The first example of judgment is the angels when they sinned. The common Jewish tradition was that "the sons of God" in Genesis 6:1–5 (understood as angels) had sexual relations with women. As a result, God judged them at that time (see 1 Enoch 6–10; compare 1 Peter 3:19–20; Jude 1:6).
- in chains of darkness: This phrase reflects a common ancient description of the underworld. It is probably a metaphor that pictures a place of deep darkness and confinement.

2 Peter 2:4–10

Three examples of judgment in the Old Testament show that God will protect and vindicate people who remain faithful to him. These examples also show that God will condemn those who deny him, including the false teachers (see 2:3).

2 Peter 2:5

The second example of judgment is that God did not spare the ancient world during the time of Noah. In the great flood, God destroyed all human life except for Noah and his family (see Genesis 6–8).

2 Peter 2:6

The third example of judgment is that God condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah. The people in these cities were very evil, so God sent sulfur and fire from the sky to destroy them (Genesis 19:24). Peter focuses on the result of this action: The cities were turned into heaps of ashes.

2 Peter 2:7–8

The Old Testament does not describe Lot as a very righteous man (see "Lot" Profile). However, he stayed mostly faithful to God. Some later Jewish writings also describe him as righteous (see Wisdom of Solomon 10:6; 19:17).

2 Peter 2:9

the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials: Noah's family and Lot show this truth (2:5; 2:7). The Lord is faithful to his people. The people Peter wrote to needed assurance that their struggles to live godly lives, while facing false teaching and the scorn of the world, would be rewarded.

2 Peter 2:10a

- The corrupt desires of the flesh: This refers to any kind of illicit sexual desire. It may also include homosexual behavior, since Peter mentions Sodom and Gomorrah (2:6).
- The false teachers were very arrogant. They refused to listen to any authority except their own.

2 Peter 2:10b

glorious beings: These are probably evil angels, unlike the angels in 2:11. It is wrong to make fun of evil angels, because they still show signs of the glorious way God first created them. They have real power and can be a real danger to humans.

2 Peter 2:10–16

This description of the false teachers focuses more on how they were living than on what they were teaching.

2 Peter 2:11

not even angels ... dare to accuse evil angels of speaking against God. But the false teachers were so full of pride that they did not hesitate to do so.

2 Peter 2:13

reveling in their deception as they feast with you: Compare Jude 1:12. Early Christians often shared fellowship meals to honor the Lord (see Acts 2:46; 6:1). The false teachers used these meals as opportunities to deceive true believers.

Some manuscripts say They revel in their fellowship meals as they feast with you. If correct, these false teachers were using the meals for self-indulgence (see 1 Corinthians 11:20–22).

2 Peter 2:15

who loved the wages of wickedness: Balaam asked God for guidance, but he still wanted to go his own way so that he could receive Balak's money (see Numbers 22–24). The Old Testament account suggests that Balaam was greedy. Jewish tradition later expanded this idea (see Numbers Rabbah 20:10; Mishnah Avot 5:22; Philo, Moses 1:266–268).

2 Peter 2:17–22

Peter continues to describe the false teachers by showing how they harm other people.

2 Peter 2:18

those who are just escaping: The false teachers cleverly targeted new believers. These were people who had only recently committed themselves to Christ.

2 Peter 2:19

False teaching often attracts people by promising freedom from authority. But this kind of freedom is not real (Romans 6:16). The false teachers celebrated what they thought was freedom (see 2 Peter 2:10). In truth, they were slaves to sin and corruption.

2 Peter 2:20

their final condition is worse than it was at first: The false teachers, or the people who followed them, had known the truth. But they chose to reject it. Their deliberate choice placed them in a much worse situation than when they sinned without understanding.

2 Peter 2:22

- "A dog returns to its vomit": In biblical times, people did not see dogs as friendly family animals. They saw them as wild and unclean.
- "A sow that is washed goes back to her wallowing in the mud": This saying may come from a well-known book of wisdom called Ahiqar from around 500 BC. One version says, "My son, you have been to me like the pig who went into the hot bath with people of quality, and when it came out of the hot bath, it saw a filthy hole and went down and wallowed in it" (Ahiqar 8:18).

2 Peter 3:1

This is now my second letter to you: The first letter was probably 1 Peter.

2 Peter 3:1–13

Peter moves from condemning the false teachers to encouraging the believers. The false teachers doubted that Christ would return, so Peter needed to teach clearly about this truth. Christians must hold onto the message that the apostles taught about the day of judgment. They should live godly lives as they wait for that day.

2 Peter 3:2

- The holy prophets of the Old Testament predicted the day of the Lord, when God would judge his enemies (see study note on 1:19).
- commanded by our Lord and Savior: Jesus had taught the church through the apostles.

2 Peter 3:3

- In the last days: Peter was not only predicting something in the future. He was also speaking about the situation of those he was writing to at that time. In the New Testament, the phrase the last days refers to the period between the first coming of Jesus and his second coming (see Acts 2:17; Hebrews 1:2). This is the time when God begins to fulfill his promises.
- scoffers will come: See Proverbs 1:22; 9:7–8; 13:1. These people refuse to take the truth seriously. Instead of using evidence or clear reasoning, they belittle the truth and make fun of it

2 Peter 3:4

since our fathers fell asleep: The false teachers were probably claiming that nothing had really changed in history. They argued that, even though God promised to act, God had never intervened and never would.

2 Peter 3:5

- Creation is the first evidence that the false teachers were wrong. Change does happen. If God made the world, then he is also able to destroy it.
- the earth was formed out of water and by water: See Genesis 1:2, 6–10.

2 Peter 3:7

The Old Testament often connects fire with the day of the Lord (see Isaiah 30:30; 66:15–16).

2 Peter 3:8

Peter refers to Psalm 90:4. God works according to his own sense of time, and he will send his Son when the time is right.

2 Peter 3:10

- The elements might refer to the basic parts of the physical universe or to the sun, moon, and stars.
- its works will be laid bare: The Greek wording here is difficult to interpret. The most likely meaning is that creation will stand before God at the time of judgment, and God will see that it deserves his judgment.

2 Peter 3:12

- anticipate and hasten the coming of the day of God: God's people can help bring the end closer by turning away from sin and by living in a godly way (compare Acts 3:19–20).
- the elements will melt in the heat: Compare Micah 1:3–4; see also Isaiah 63:19–64:1.

2 Peter 3:13

a new heaven and a new earth: See Isaiah 65:17; 66:22; Revelation 21.

2 Peter 3:15

our beloved brother Paul: The New Testament tells us only a little about the relationship between the apostles Peter and Paul. Some people think the two apostles were hostile toward each other because of the dispute in Antioch (Galatians 2:11–14). But the New Testament indicates otherwise.

Peter and Paul about the good news for non-Jews (Gentiles) (Acts 11:2–18; 15:7–11). Silvanus and Mark worked with both Paul and Peter (see 1 Peter 5:12–13). According to early Christian tradition, both apostles were killed in Rome during the same persecution under Nero in the mid-60s AD.

2 Peter 3:16

Peter probably knew almost all of the apostle Paul's letters at this time. His words suggest that he viewed Paul's letters as Scripture, or as writings that carried God's authority.

2 Peter 3:17–18

Peter repeats his purpose. He wants to protect his audience from false teachers so that they can grow in grace. He ends the letter with words of praise to our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.